

Wrobel Turns Down Draft Modlinski Hoping Pros Give Him Chance

By MARK LEIBSON
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Professional baseball contracts don't come a dime a dozen these days and when one is offered, but turned down, there better be a good reason.

And there was.

Ron Wrobel, a left-handed pitcher from the Windy City of Chicago, was offered a substantial bonus contract by the Los Angeles Dodgers upon graduation from Quigley South High.

In the summer draft of 1973, LA picked the prep southpaw in the 20th round, which made Wrobel the 464th player out of 727 drafted by the major leagues. Considering college players were also eligible for the draft, Wrobel felt honored.

The 19-year-old declined the pro offer though and chose to continue his career at the University of Texas at El Paso, a school that competes in the toughest baseball conference in the nation.

As soon as Wrobel walked onto the U.T. El Paso campus, he joined forces with a righthander by the name of Dan Modlinski, also a Chicago native.

Although the two were from different parts of town, they quickly realized that they had faced each other before, back when Modlinski was a senior while Wrobel played varsity ball as a freshman in Chicago.

"I don't remember Modlinski when I pitched against his high school," joked Wrobel, "because he was probably sitting on the bench."

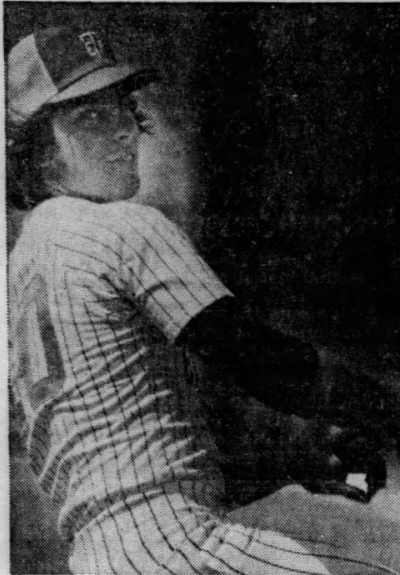
As the two acquainted themselves on Coach Andy Cohen's baseball diamond, they soon decided their goals were identical.

"My ambition is to play in the pros," said Modlinski who has been termed by Cohen as "the best righthander ever to pitch for the Miners."

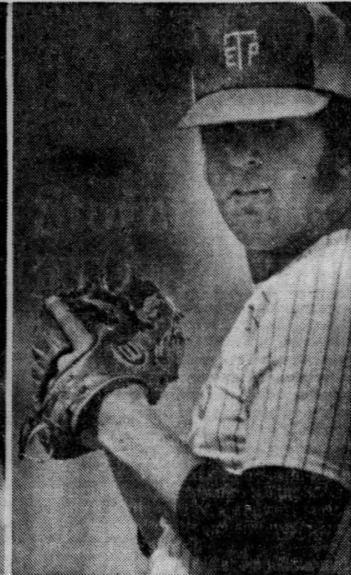
"I've talked to too many scouts who have told me I have the ability and now I just wait for the summer draft," said Modlinski. "I think a lot depends on how I do in Western Athletic Conference competition."

While Modlinski begins the long wait for a phone call from American or National League teams, Wrobel plans to take it easy for a couple of years before looking toward Modlinski's path.

"When I was drafted, my parents wanted me to go to school and the reason I decided upon going to U.T. El Paso," said Wrobel, "was because the



Ron Wrobel



Dan Modlinski

WAC is the best baseball conference. It'll be a good experience pitching against such schools as Arizona State and Arizona. That'll be as good experience wise as playing in Class A ball.

While the Dodgers and other teams keep close contact with the 180-pounder, Wrobel will be the one person in the entire world that'll decide when he's ready for pro ball.

"If I think I'm ready by my sophomore or junior year, I'd sign," acknowledged Wrobel. "Right now, I have to work on my control. I don't walk a lot of people but to play pro ball, you have to have pin-point accuracy. You have to put the ball exactly where you want it."

Cohen is just praying that his freshman hurler will remain on campus for his entire four years of eligibility. "I hope Ron stays with us, but when you get around 21-years-old, it's time to go," Cohen said. "After that age, you get to be an old man with young kids fighting to reach the pros."

Wrobel realizes he sacrificed his dream by joining the Miners instead of Los Angeles. "But another chance will come," he felt.

Pressure is building inside of Modlinski as he nears the completion of his college career.

Knowing a poor season would ruin his dream, Modlinski

started the 1975 campaign in record-setting form with a no-hitter against Texas Tech.

Telling "Moe" how outstanding his performance was would lead the righthander into believing the person praising him knew nothing about baseball.

"I was a little upset with the way I pitched," Modlinski remarked. "I wasn't overpowering and my fast ball was not working too hot for me. There is something mechanically wrong with the way I'm pitching and I don't know what it is."

Whatever seems to be bothering the 210-pounder hasn't hurt his ability to beat opponents. After suffering his only setback against Hardin-Simmons, Modlinski once again faced Texas Tech and once again the Red Raiders were raided of enough hits to produce a victory.

"A key to pitching good," Moe warned, "is to always be thinking when you're on the mound. Concentration means a lot. Sometimes I'll feel myself concentrating like in the game last year against Arizona when I had seven strikeouts in four innings. But all of a sudden, I just started throwing the ball without thinking and Arizona began to hit me."

Modlinski feels his main target is to improve the velocity on his fast ball. "My

control has improved greatly and the curve ball I lost last season has come back thanks to Syd Cohen (Miner pitching coach)," said Modlinski.

"It's hard getting good velocity on the fast ball and if I can obtain it by the time we play Arizona, I honestly think we can beat them," Moe added.

Wrobel, Modlinski and lefty George Landreth will be counted upon heavily to guide the Miners through Western Athletic Conference competition and if the trio can live up to their expectation, U.T. El Paso might find themselves in the playoffs come May.

"It's possible, not probable, for us to make it to the playoffs," said Modlinski, "and that's what we're all working for."

Under a National Collegiate Athletic Association (NCAA) rules, a playoff system will match the first two teams of the WAC Southern Division with the top two Northern Division finishers to decide the conference representative to the national tournament.

A lot will depend on U.T. El Paso's chances of capturing a playoff spot in two months, but if Wrobel and Modlinski forget about their future for now and concentrate on the present, Coach Cohen's Miners might make his first post-season appearance.

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